

BEFORE

A rich supply of lucrative resources led to competition between European powers for a stake in India. As the Mughal Empire's controlling grip on the area weakened, British influence increased.

RICHES OF THE EAST

Europe's craze for spices made India very alluring. The lucrative spice trade had tempted the Portuguese to India since the mid-15th century. By the 16th century, India was visited by Italians, English, French, and Dutch, all eager to trade, seek adventure, or spread Christianity in the area.

EAST INDIA COMPANIES (EICs)

To rival Portugal, the EICs were formed by England (1600) and the Netherlands (1602)

◀ 276–77. These

companies acted as trade organizations, and later provided a military presence in the region.



ENGLISH EAST INDIA COMPANY COAT OF ARMS

MUGHAL EMPIRE

The English EIC prospered, and worked with the ruling Mughal

emperors ◀ 244–45 well into the 19th century. However, as the British fortunes rose, the fragile Mughal Empire went into decline.

BRITISH INVOLVEMENT

Short reigns, protracted war, and peasant revolts undermined the Mughals. Indian provinces became more independent of central rule, paving the way for British interference.

The British Raj

The desire for power and wealth has led nations to expand their influence far beyond their frontiers. India became the jewel in the British Empire's crown, and the British Raj (Hindi for "rule")—which ran from 1858 to 1947—was the culmination of decades of British involvement and domination in the Indian subcontinent.

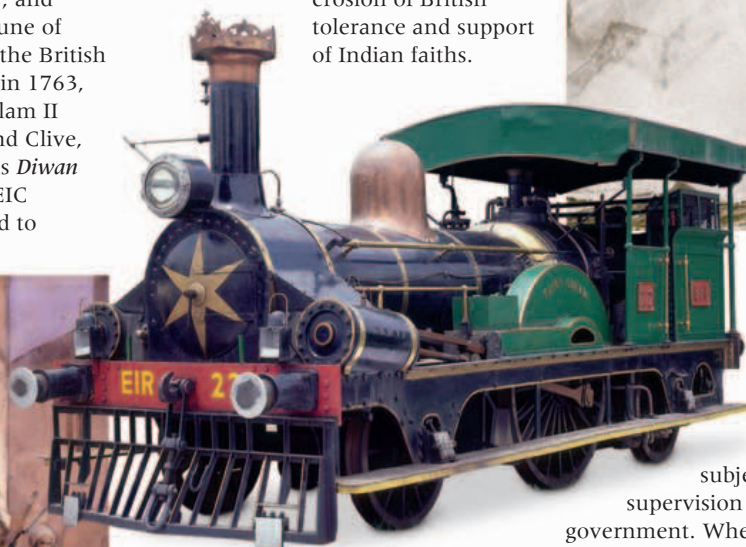
At the turn of the 18th century, the long-established English East India Company (see BEFORE) enabled Britain to enjoy unprecedented privileges in India, with footholds in economic, political, and military life. To protect this situation, the EIC had increased the number of troops deemed necessary to defend its establishments. Rivalry with other trading companies, especially the French, was fierce and led to the Seven Years War (see pp.296–97), a slow, stuttering campaign for British expansion and control. In 1756, under Robert Clive, a soldier and statesman described as "the conqueror of India," the British claimed the richest Mughal province, Bengal, in the northeast of the country. This became the foundation of British rule in India. The recapture of Calcutta by Clive in late 1756, the storming of nearby French Chandernagore in early 1757, and Clive's success at Plassey in June of that year were milestones in the British domination of India. Finally, in 1763, the Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II formally inducted the EIC, and Clive, into the Mughal hierarchy. As *Diwan* (chancellor) for Bengal, the EIC received a title that amounted to

Viceroy Curzon at the Maharajah's Palace

Nathaniel George Curzon (fourth right) was Viceroy of India from 1898 to 1905, and ruled in place of the monarch. Devastating famines, and a dispute with Lord Kitchener, chief of the Indian army, led to his resignation.

sovereignty over the province. The British gained administrative powers throughout India and became more of a government than a trading concern.

British influence knew no bounds, from the building of roads, an extensive railroad network, and schools, to an administrative system of officials that emerged as a model for the British civil service. There was an agreement to allow Christian missions to operate in India, aided by influential figures in London such as the antislavery campaigner William Wilberforce (see pp.308–09). Hinduism was seen as something from which the people were to be emancipated. This evangelical zeal led to the eventual erosion of British tolerance and support of Indian faiths.



Indian locomotive

The *Fairy Queen*, built in Britain in 1855 for the East Indian Railways, still survives and is the world's oldest working engine.

subject to increased supervision from the British government. When its royal charter—sovereign permission to operate as a corporation—was renewed in 1813, the EIC had to surrender its monopoly of trade in India, allowing other corporations to operate in the region.

The Indian mutiny

Under the EIC, there was some rebellious behavior among Indian soldiers (sepoys) serving in the British army, who were aggrieved at their treatment. These sepoys bore the brunt of the First British–Afghan war (1838–42) and were shipped to China to fight in the Opium Wars (see pp.354–55).

By the late 1770s the East India Company was burdened with massive military expenditure and was in dire financial straits. India was of huge national importance to Britain, and so the British government decided to overhaul the EIC. The Regulating Act of 1773 resulted in the EIC's becoming

The Siege of Lucknow

The British Garrison in Lucknow, in northern India, was besieged by Indian rebels on July 1, 1857. Despite the large numbers of mutineers, the siege was finally ended by Sir Colin Campbell's relief force in November 1857.

